

The scenario developed in the river valleys today indicates that the state is still not looking for a scientific or democratic solution. The political expediency and corruption involving misuse of not just monetary, but also natural resources is a reason behind the devastating impact on the riverine ecosystem, its living communities and the river itself. The calamity in Kosi as well as Hirakud dam are obvious examples of what can happen when the science of nature is ignored.

In a world which has become increasingly hungry for natural resources with consumer-driven lifestyles and exploitative technology, river basins are merely seen as a stock and puddle of water. Large dams to tap and exploit water capital have been tried since Bhakra Nangal, which is more than exposed now. Not less than Rs 70,000 crore has been spent on large and medium dams before 1990. In spite of 4,600 large dams having been built across the country, not more than 6 to 15 per

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cent of agricultural land in each state is irrigated by these projects. Neither the drinking water crisis nor the flood problem has been resolved. Moreover, almost Rs 1 lakh crore, officially spent during 1991-2004, has not added an acre of net irrigated area through surface channels.

Dams, on the other hand, have not only drowned and destroyed water bodies, but also land, which have fallen prey to submergence and water-logging, salinisation and canal breaches in the beneficiary area, as in the case of Bhakra Nangal, Ukai and Sardar Sarovar. In these regions, problems of water scarcity and floods in downstream areas and serious destruction of land and forest communities in the catchment area are rampant. Tall claims of rehabilitation against displacement and compensation against environmental losses have proved to be futile with no adequate resources, such as land or alternative livelihood, allotted. Efficient planning with political will is missing too. Pandit Jawaharlal Nehru once called large dams 'temples of modern India' (1955), but within the next three years, realised his folly and termed those a 'disease of gigantism'.

The river either dies or turns away. Kosi has followed the latter path. Why? It's not Nepal's doing, nor is it the fury of nature. It's the silt, which has accumulated along with water, with dams, barrages and embankments as barriers; that lifts the river, uprooting it from the bed unnaturally and finally compels it to deviate and prove to be a bane. This is not just an administrative folly, but a criminal act, looking at the death toll.

Claims to regulate the water releases and control floods thereby prove absolutely unreliable since blunders in the dam operation drowned Surat city downstream of Ukai and 16 districts of Orissa below the Hirakud dam. The region of Saurashtra, Gujarat, which has become a water grave today with breaches in the Narmada canal creating more floods, is not yet prepared to preserve or use this valuable resource before it recedes, leaving the same land and rivers dry. This is the water that is wasted and also proves to be a curse rather than a blessing for drought-prone and drought-affected areas. This needs to be tapped to free the farthest regions of Kutch and Saurashtra from age-long dependence on elusive rivers like the Narmada. Almost all claims on bringing the river to doorsteps re-

